

Photos by JULIE ANDERSON / Daily Courier

Medford artist Anthony Vella stands in front of one of his murals, which he's completing in his back yard. In all, four panels will be mounted in the Bartlett-Middleford parking lot garage connection at 34 N. Bartlett St.

Muralist From 1A



Inspired by nature, Anthony Vella worked out the designs for the four panels, which were commissioned by the City of Medford.

"I wanted to incorporate animals that I see every day," he said.

With panels that could mimic the size of a giant dollar bill, elements of currency also worked their way into the murals. Vella said when he was designing the artwork, he realized he had collected a lot of different foreign currency, so he studied them and chose aspects that he liked to work into the design.

"I didn't directly pull from anything," he said. "If someone says it looks like money, I'll give 'em a high five."

Some of the murals — which are green, turquoise, pink and blue — have words declaring what were once thought to be the basic elements, like "earth" and "water." However, Vella said he wasn't necessarily trying to theme the murals around an element, and they're not all represented. "Fire" is conspicuously missing.

"I like doing that," he said. "Setting up the thought and not finishing it."

Like the elements of his design, the style that Vella chose doesn't fall into any one specific category. His initial foray into the world of art was doing graffiti on the streets, he said, so the murals incorporate some graffiti-like style. He was also formally trained in calligraphy and fine art, so those elements worked their way in, too.

"I combine a bunch of styles," he said. "It's not realistic, but it's not cartoon."

Wednesday, Vella was outside under the sun, using it to help dry the acrylic detail work he was painting.

"I've got some touch up to do on everything," he said. "They're mostly done. Just crispening a few lines."

Each of the four murals is 4-feet-by-16-feet, totaling 256 square feet, according to the city of Medford. The art will be placed in the Bartlett-Middleford parking garage connection at 34 N. Bartlett St.

The city awarded Vella $10,000 for the project.

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Prayer From 1A

"How much litigation has there actually been across the nation?" Krohn asked.

"A lot," Nuttall responded.

Nuttall, who started working for the city not long after several new councilors including Krohn were seated in January 2025, said she was concerned from the beginning about the legal defensibility of the process for choosing who delivers the prayers.

Many cities are examining their practices and adopting policies because of litigation concerns, Nuttall said.

The U.S. Supreme Court has ruled that government meetings can start with prayer, but governments must protect people's First Amendment rights to free speech and the free exercise of religion. Prayers shouldn't condemn people or try to convert them to a specific religion.

City Councilor Joel King complimented the city attorney for drafting a policy that's not arbitrary or capricious, and gives the council a way to move forward with public prayers. He said prayer and respecting the Constitution are both important.

"Those are two values that I deeply hold — and to do both at the same time not only is essential and legal, it's wonderful," King said.

Councilor Victoria Marshall pointed to a long line of people who have prayed publicly, including George Washington, Abraham Lincoln, Franklin D. Roosevelt and chaplains for Congress.

"This is a tradition in our nation," she said. "It is protected. I believe that the community has the desire to continue it."

Councilor Indra Nicholas said the City Council does need to fix its informal process of picking people to deliver invocations.

"We do need to include all faiths, I believe, and not just certain people we know to give invocation. I love my Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ. That's who I would pray to. But other people have other religions, and we should respect that, so that they should be able to come and give invocation as well. We need this policy in place," Nicholas said.

Under the proposed rules, city staff and elected officials including councilors would not be allowed to deliver an opening prayer, and they couldn't review or censor the content of another person's planned prayer.

Courts have ruled that cities can limit who delivers invocations to people from congregations within their own communities, and Grants Pass may adopt that approach. Grants Pass could also allow local residents who belong to a congregation outside the urban growth boundary to deliver an invocation.

For example, a Grants Pass resident who attends a synagogue in Ashland could deliver an opening invocation.

Although he voted to continue forward with adopting a prayer policy, Councilor Rob Pell had concerns with some of the draft language, such as that people belong to a congregation.

"If we've got someone with no religious affiliation just beyond a love for the Creator, where does that person fit in this concept? Are they eliminated?" he asked.

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Hasan From 1A

an execution could make the process "much more transparent" and inform the public about all that capital punishment entails. Those are benefits that she said would be useful at a time when Pike's botched execution has raised fresh questions about the manner by which criminal defendants are put to death for their crimes.

"I think it could possibly be a good idea because it would be transparent and the public would be fully aware that it's happening," she said.

When many states have had difficulty carrying out lethal injections due to difficulty accessing drugs or finding medical professionals willing to participate in executions, firing squads are coming to be seen as a less inhumane alternative, said Brenner Fissell, a professor at Villanova Law and vice president of the National Institute of Military Justice.

"Firing squads can be a quicker, cleaner, more precise way to execute a prisoner," he said. "I don't think that's what's motivating this. There's a perceived masculinity and military-ness to firing squads that is part of the aura Hegseth is trying to emphasize — the 'lethality culture.'"

Elisabeth Semel, co-director of the Death Penalty Clinic at UC Berkeley Law, said Hegseth's announcement raises a host of legal and public policy questions, including concerns for the dignity of the defendant, who will be eligible to view the execution and what the Trump administration has in mind in opting for an unusual spectacle.

Though there has been long-running discussion about the idea of televising an execution, "I don't recall a situation in which it was instigated by the government. I think that also raises serious questions about what is the motivation of the government," she said.

"This is a president who's about spectacle and that's, I think, precisely the message that he intends to deliver," Semel said, adding that she was skeptical that the administration had given a second thought to the legal and social questions being presented by the decision.

Trump, who approved Hasan's execution, has previously been critical of public executions in Iran, at times using the possibility of protesters being killed by the Iranian government as a possible rationale for military action that preceded his ultimate choice to attack Iran on Feb. 28.

"We've been told that the killing in Iran is stopping," Trump told reporters on Jan. 14. "It's stopping, and there's no plan for executions."

In his State of the Union address just days before launching the Iran war, Trump reiterated, "We stopped them from hanging a lot of them with the threat of serious violence."

The White House on Thursday referred questions about the plans for the livestreamed execution to the Pentagon.

Hegseth was asked Wednesday if Hasan had made any final requests or reached out to the Trump administration. The Pentagon chief replied: "Don't care. We'll see him on Dec. 3."

Empty Bowls event in Grants Pass, Ashland helps feed those in need

By Kathleen Alaks
of the Daily Courier

With current economic conditions, rising grocery prices and cuts to food stamp programs, more families are having difficulty putting food on the table.

Addressing that struggle is the aim of Empty Bowls, an international project to help fight hunger by raising funds to feed and support those experiencing food insecurity.

Empty Bowls is a simple soup and bread supper, with hot soups from local restaurants and caterers, fresh bread from local bakers and handmade ceramic bowls donated by local artisans.

"For me, I appreciate the intention of Empty Bowls to remind us that a good meal doesn't need to be fancy; it can be as simple as a little soup and a little bread. It's the sharing of the meal with love and in good company that really makes all the difference," said Meg Wade, executive director of Peace House, which organizes the Empty Bowls event in Ashland.

"That we can come together for that experience to make sure we keep our community fed — that's really wonderful."

In Ashland, Empty Bowls will take place on Oct. 23 from 4-7 p.m. Tickets are $25 for adults, $10 for youth, available at peacehouse.net.

In Grants Pass, Empty Bowls is on Monday at 6 p.m. Tickets are $35 in advance, $40 at the door, available at optionsonline.org.

At each meal, guests choose a handmade ceramic bowl to fill with food, then take the bowl home as a reminder of the cause.

The bowls are made and donated by local artisans.

For the Grants Pass event, members of the ceramic artist group Clayfolk, made "hundreds and hundreds of bowls," said Sarah Small, with Options for Southern Oregon, which has been organizing the Grants Pass event for at least 20 years.

The potters also donated 85 ceramic pieces for a silent auction, which supports the event beyond ticket sales.

The silent auction is currently open for bidding, and will run through Oct. 14. The auction link can be accessed from the Options website, optionsonline.org.

Ceramic bowls for the Ashland event are being made by young people in the community, Wade said, including students from Ashland High School, North Medford High School and Southern Oregon University.

Rogue Pottery Supply provided clay, work space and instruction for the Ashland students and is also serving as a donation site for potters who want to give a bowl they have made.

New this year, the Ashland event organizers are offering a "Trade-In Ticket" option, available only for advance ticket purchases.

"We're encouraging long-time attendees to bring back a bowl in excellent condition in exchange for a reduced-price ticket," Wade said.

Stop by the Peace House office during October with a bowl donation and get a ticket to the dinner for $15. Trade-in tickets are available only in advance, not at the door.

For the second year, the Grants Pass Empty Bowls is being held at the Josephine County Fairgrounds.

"We were really happy with how it turned out last year," Small said. "The new venue allowed us to display even more bowls and silent auction items than we were able to in the past."

Fourteen restaurants are participating this year. New to the event are Joe's Sports Bar & Grill with creamy chicken tortilla soup and Rogue Salad Company with potato kale soup.

Other soup offerings include chicken poblano, tomato basil, carrot ginger with hemp seeds, Hungarian mushroom and salmon chowder.

Restaurants confirmed so far for the Ashland meal are La Briccola, Larks, Maren Faye Catering, The Noble Fox, Six or Seven Soups and Nous.

The list of participants is still being finalized, Wade said, "so attendees can expect to find more of their favorite restaurants to be represented at the event."

Rise Up! Artisan Bread and La Baguette will provide bread, Griffin Creek Coffee Roasters will serve coffee and volunteers from Uncle Food's Diner, the Peace House meal program, will be contributing cookies and banana bread, a perennial favorite.

"And our Uncle Food's Diner chef, David Jimenez, will be making a pumpkin curry soup with pumpkins from Fry Family Farm," Wade said.

Proceeds from the Ashland event benefit Uncle Food's Diner, which serves 80-100 meals each week at Peace House. A portion also is shared with other community meal programs and Food Angels, a program of gleaners.

Proceeds from the Grants Pass dinner support Options for Southern Oregon and the Josephine County Food Bank.

"Too many of our friends and neighbors are struggling to put food on the table, including families who never imagined they would need to turn to a food pantry for help," said Josephine Sze, executive director of the Josephine County Food Bank.

"Events like Empty Bowls remind us that food is about so much more than nourishment; it's about dignity, connection, and ensuring that everyone in our community has a seat at the table."

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Fill an empty bowl

WHAT: Empty Bowls, a soup supper to raise money and awareness of hunger in Josephine County
WHEN: 6 p.m. Monday
WHERE: Josephine County Fairgrounds, 1351 Fairgrounds Road, Grants Pass
TICKETS: $35 advance, $40 door; online ticket sales end at 8 p.m. Sunday
EXTRA: A silent auction of ceramic items and other artwork, will be open through Wednesday; it is currently open online.
INFORMATION: 541-476-2373, optionsonline.org

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WHAT: Empty Bowls, a soup supper to raise money and awareness of hunger in Jackson County
WHEN: 4-7 p.m. Oct. 23
WHERE: Wesley Hall, First United Methodist Church, 175 N. Main At., Ashland
TICKETS: $25 adults, $10 for youth and students
EXTRA: Pottery and artwork will be for sale at the event
INFORMATION: 541-482-9625, peacehouse.net

GRANTS PASS DOWNS
2026 FALL RACE MEET

SUNDAY, OCTOBER 11
FAN APPRECIATION DAY.
FREE Drawing for Gift Bags after every race. Must be present to win.



MONDAY, OCTOBER 12
CLOSING DAY.
The 2026 Fall Meet concludes with the Far West Futurity and the Grants Pass "Mile". Special Holiday Post Time of 1:00 PM

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DON JACKSON RACING FACILITY
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www.racingontherogue.org
FREE PARKING • ADMISSION $5.00
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Oct 11 4:00 PM Post Time • Oct 12 1:00 PM Post Time